AFROVESCENCE

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A vibrant visual and poetry collection

2026

BLACK IS PRESENCE

PHOTOGRAPHY BY: DIEGO MORA

POETRY: MARIE-PAUL DUWAI-SOWA

BLACK IS PRECIOUS

BLACK IS PERSEVERANCE

BLACK IS POSSIBILITY

BLACK CODE SUITE

by: Marie-Paul Duwai-Sowa

after 'Black Code Suite' by LL Cool J, Sona Jobarteh

Traditionally, a walk is what carries you from where you are to where you want to be.
So when they tell me to rush, it feels foreign to my being.
My DNA requires grace for slow, grand entrances.
Time to cruise as I glide with every step on the rich earth I was blessed with.
Only royalty walks like this, it's a stride you cannot replicate.
And a swag that holds no duplicates.
It identifies me in a sea of sameness, and takes up space in places with hostile faces.
I feel the earth shake as I repeatedly plant and lift my feet.
Intentionally and steadily, my pace even mirrors the way I speak.
Like every step, each syllable lands with weight.
Holds together a nation, and conjures up a feeling of determination.
To remain grounded in the truth that does not even need to be spoken.
I know exactly who I am, and where I am going.

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IDENTIFICATION

by: Marie-Paul Duwai-Sowa

How do you prove a life,
tell me, what method best applies.

Thin pages and small booklets
are requested of me
but some I can't find,
and others I've never seen.

Either way,
how can one page possibly encapsulate
who I am
and all I've had to face.

If you've got any question,
just look at my face.
Trace each wrinkle and fold
Feel as they have deepened with age.
Sense the utmost joy,
the jubilation
the praise,
the worry
the disdain
the despair
in times when life felt most unfair.

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IDENTIFICATION CONT'D

by: Marie-Paul Duwai-Sowa

No A4 paper
can tell you about that,
about how high I've had to climb,
how long I've had to walk,
how hard I have fought
to arrive at where I thought
I would be safe.

Still I must prove my place.
Force myself to wipe my eyes dry
and try,
because everyday I wake up and face debates about my rights,
partially granted and yet again denied.

Even when the creases,
framing both my eyes
should be enough to validate the value of my life.

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ERASURE

by: Marie-Paul Duwai-Sowa

What does it feel like,
When it creeps into your skin past midnight.
Diminishing what lies within
Until when come sunlight,
You cease feeling existence
Is your birthright.

You have been classified myth.
A mission to be proven non-existent.
Reduced to dust on a marble top,
with one swipe, or many
You must become air.

Whatever remains
Thrown into the fireplace,
For warmth,
Lost in the flames.
Truth to dust.

But truth is a living, breathing thing.
A walking, eating thing.
It desires nourishment
And monuments.

ERASURE CONT'D

by: Marie-Paul Duwai-Sowa

And when the shadow of what was once permanent
Cannot be recognized,
There is a seismic shift
That will chip away at your future kin.

From your first to last, even your middle name will be lost.

“A people without the knowledge of their past history, origin and culture is like a tree without roots.”

– Marcus Garvey

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MON AMOUR

by: Marie-Paul Duwai-Sowa

J'essaye avec tout ce que j'ai de ne pas perdre
Mon amour,
De ne pas perdre ma joie de vivre.
Il y a des moments où je me soucie
Quand il me sent comme si le monde veut m'en tombé

Mais je me rappelle
Que ce n'est pas un accident que nous existions
Ni qu'on ait donné la chance
Le monde que nous imaginons
N'est pas loin
Chaque jour il se manifeste
Comme des rayons de soleil qui percent l'horizon

C'est pourquoi, à travers tout
Nous persistons,
Nous résistons
Et nous nous levons
Tenons fort
À notre amour

Parce que c'est tout qu'on a à partager
À liberté,
En quantités illimitées

C'est comment que je survis,
mon amour
me garde
vivante.

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WHAT LIVES IN THE HEART CAN NEVER BE TAKEN OR TRULY LOST

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WE ARE THEIR PRAYERS (PSALM 23)

by: Marie-Paul Duwai-Sowa

We are not only our ancestors' wildest dreams
We are their fervent prayers
Morning, noon and night
We are a product of their unbreakable faith

In any circumstance
They would still praise
Fall to their knees in surrender
Bow their heads and be cloaked in salvation
Hoping it would extend further down their line of creation

They would pour the holy oil
On the crown and over the home
While singing hymns accented by a tinge of heartache
They longed for the words to ring true
"It is well
it is well with my soul"
And prayed, Lord let it will be well with them too

Even at the silent whisper of a midnight call
they would rise underneath the ebony sky
interlace their fingers, and again close their eyes
exhale the pressing matters of their hearts
and cast away all burdens weighing on their minds
trusting to be provided with the comfort, clarity, and courage to survive another day.

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WE ARE THEIR PRAYERS (PSALM 23) CONT'D

by: Marie-Paul Duwai-Sowa

For the strength to hop on their feet
Sway to the claps and march to the beats
Hoping God can feel their devotion

Endless recitations daily
Until their tongues were numb
Everlasting believers with their steadfast love
what are we without their prayers,
answered and to come.

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HONOURABLE DR. JEAN AUGUSTINE

by: Marie-Paul Duwai-Sowa

Born under the warming sun of a vibrant hilly island
Arriving to lush green mountains
At times hidden under plush white blankets,
She showed us that our story does not begin or end with someone else's pen.

By dreaming into law
A policy that forever changed the way Black people's contributions were seen.
She created a season to reflect, to remember, and to celebrate.
Created space for brilliance and excellence to be recognized.

Since, thirty years of black accomplishments have been given a spotlight.
In institutions, workplaces and classrooms.
So even the littlest minds can understand the value of black lives.
And see themselves in another's eyes.

A teacher first.
Her dedication to giving, inspiring and uplifting,
Alongside her passion for community, justice and advocacy.
Seems only right in light of her lifetime of pioneering.

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HONOURABLE DR. JEAN AUGUSTINE CONT'D

by: Marie-Paul Duwai-Sowa

As the first African-Canadian woman elected to the House of Commons.
She proves you can write your own story,
And still make room for others to share theirs too.

Let us continue her legacy,
Ensure blackness is not just history
But elevated in the present,
And our presence remains highlighted for all to see.

For this gift
We thank you dearly,
Honourable Dr. Jean Augustine.

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“The seeds of a fruitful society are sown in the minds of its youth.”

— Honourable Dr. Jean Augustine

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